

Taj Mahal

Expanding on design traditions of both Persian and Mughal architecture, the Taj Mahal near Agra was inspired by love and grief and took over 20,000 workers 22 years to build. In 1631, the fifth Mughal emperor Shah Jahan (1592–1666) ordered the mausoleum to be built for his late wife, Mumtaz Mahal (1593–1631), who had died giving birth to their 14th child. Wanting the mausoleum to be more beautiful than anything ever built, he rejected red sandstone as its main fabric, which had become the primary Mughal building material, and chose instead white marble, decorated with inlay work of semi-precious and coloured stones. The Persian chief architect, Ustad Ahmad Lahauri, designed it to be perfectly symmetrical: a square building in the centre of a marble plinth almost 6 metres (20 ft) high and 96 metres (315 ft) square, with a huge double-constructed central dome. The inner dome is 24 metres (79 ft) high, and the central octagonal structure beneath it is surrounded by a two-levelled passageway with an octagonal tower at each corner. A raised rectangular pool reflects the building serenely.

